

[BRAND](#) · [COLOR](#) · [TYPE](#) · [COMPONENTS](#)

# WHITE FIRST TEAL CARRIES SLATE FRAMES RED SIGNALS

Blackbird's digital system runs on six tokens. Off-white (#FAFAFA) carries the page. Teal does heavy lifting on accents, fills, and links. Red is the second accent — stronger, more declarative — carrying signal, callouts, headlines, and counterweight moments. Slate anchors structural neutrals and the warm emphasis surface. Black carries display type; dark slate (#1E293B) carries reading text and the cool dark-card. Two layers: raw primitives at the bottom, semantic roles on top. Components only ever reference the semantic layer.

## 01 · FOUNDATIONS

### SIX TOKENS, TWO FONTS, NO DECORATION

Off-white surface, black content, two brand colors that each carry meaning. Teal is the workhorse: surfaces, fills, links, dividers. Red is the second accent, used for emphasis, headlines, counterweight callouts, and signal moments where teal would feel too soft. Slate is structure, not brand: it anchors neutrals and the warm emphasis surface, and recedes. No pastel cards. No filled containers fighting the content for attention.

#### COLOR WEIGHTS

White (#FAFAFA) 50–55% surface

Teal 12–15% accent + fills

#### TYPE FAMILIES

Headlines Futura Bold

Body Avenir

#### HARD RULES

Gradients Never

Underlines Never

|            |                          |
|------------|--------------------------|
| Red        | 8–10% signal + accent    |
| Slate      | 12–15% structure         |
| Black      | 5–7% display / headlines |
| Dark slate | 5–8% reading + cool card |

|              |                              |
|--------------|------------------------------|
| Section nums | Futura Bold, two-digit       |
| Code/data    | Avenir (no separate mono)    |
| Squarespace  | europa fallback (Avenir N/A) |

|               |                            |
|---------------|----------------------------|
| Centered body | Hero / cover / quote only  |
| Chart series  | Teal · Slate · Black       |
| Spacing       | 4px base, 10px card radius |
| Shadows       | Hairlines only, no glow    |
| New colors    | Add a token first          |

02 · LOGO

THREE LOCKUPS, BLACK INK, NO EFFECTS

The Blackbird mark is a side-profile bird in flat black ink. Three lockups handle every placement: horizontal (default for headers and signatures), circular (badge moments and profile photos), and bird mark (tight contexts and watermarks). On dark surfaces the logo flips to white. Never recolor to teal, red, or anything else.

HORIZONTAL LOCKUP · DEFAULT



HEADERS, SIGNATURES, FOOTERS, BUSINESS CARDS, DECKS

CIRCULAR BADGE



PROFILE PHOTOS, APP ICONS, FAVICONS, STICKER MOMENTS

BIRD MARK



WATERMARKS, VERY SMALL SIZES, TIGHT CONTEXTS

ON SLATE-DARK · WHITE LOCKUP



ON DARK · WHITE BADGE



MARK ON DARK · WHITE





### CLEAR SPACE

Reserve a margin around the logo equal to the cap height of the wordmark (x). No text, image, or graphic element enters that space. On photo backgrounds, the dark overlay extends through the clear-space zone.

## LOCKUP RULES

| VARIANT           | MIN SIZE             | USE FOR                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-------------------|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Horizontal lockup | 120px wide on screen | Default. Site header, deck title slides (TOC), email signatures, footers, business cards.                                                                                      |
| Circular badge    | 48px wide            | Profile photos (LinkedIn, X, Slack), app icons, favicon, sticker. The badge is the recognizable lockup at small sizes when the wordmark would be illegible.                    |
| Bird mark         | 24px wide            | Watermarks on photos, tiny UI moments, the diamond on the cover slide, repeating-mark patterns. Don't use the bird without context if the audience doesn't know the brand yet. |

### **DON'T** RECOLOR THE LOGO

The mark stays black on light surfaces, white on dark. Never teal, never red, never gradient. Color is reserved for accents, not the brand mark itself.

### **DON'T** STRETCH, SKEW, OR ROTATE

Scale uniformly. Don't squish to fit a banner. Don't rotate the bird upright or sideways. The bird faces upper-right, always.

### **DON'T** ADD EFFECTS

No drop shadows, glows, outlines, embossing, or gradients. Flat black or flat white, full stop.

### **DON'T** PLACE ON BUSY BACKGROUNDS WITHOUT OVERLAY

If the logo sits on a photo, the photo must carry a dark overlay heavy enough that the logo reads cleanly — check contrast, don't hit a number. If on a colored surface, only #FAFAFA, #FFFFFF, slate-700/800, or off-black are valid hosts.

### **DO** CHOOSE THE LOCKUP THAT FITS THE CONTAINER

Horizontal first. Circular when the space is square or round. Bird mark only when nothing else fits or the audience already knows the brand.

### **DO** BIRD MARK ON CONTENT SLIDES, HORIZONTAL LOCKUP ON TOC + COVER

Cover slide carries no logo (the project name does the work). TOC slide carries the horizontal lockup, right-center area, ~2.5" wide. Every other content slide carries just the bird mark in the bottom-right corner. Bird mark = quiet brand presence on the most-used layout. Horizontal lockup = louder brand statement, used sparingly.

# SIX HEX VALUES DO 90% OF THE WORK

Two layers. Primitives are raw values, never referenced by components directly. The semantic layer assigns each role to a primitive. When the brand teal shifts, one line updates and everything follows. But before any of that — six hex values carry the majority of every surface, every accent, every section.

## THE CORE SIX

| SURFACE                  | BRAND ACCENT             | SIGNAL                  | SLATE / STRUCTURE        | BLACK / DISPLAY        | DARK SLATE / READING   |
|--------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------|--------------------------|------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>#FAFAFA</b><br>50–55% | <b>#008C95</b><br>12–15% | <b>#862633</b><br>8–10% | <b>#64748B</b><br>12–15% | <b>#000000</b><br>5–7% | <b>#1E293B</b><br>5–8% |

These six hex values carry the majority of brand color. Black #000000 is the display ink (headlines, max-contrast marks); dark slate #1E293B is the reading ink and the cool dark-card; off-black #0D0D0D is the dark section ground — the dark twin of the surface, shown in the dark set below. The 11-step scales below exist so you can pick supporting tints — hover states, subtle backgrounds, dark-section depth, hairline dividers — but every value in those scales derives from these six anchors. If a design uses a seventh hex, ask whether it earned its place. The answer is almost always no.

## FULL SCALES

### Teal — brand accent

11 steps · brand at 500 (#008C95)

|               |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| 50<br>#ECF7F8 | 100<br>#CFEEF0 | 200<br>#A0DCE0 | 300<br>#6EC6CB | 400<br>#36AAB1 | 500<br>#008C95 | 600<br>#007078 | 700<br>#00565D | 800<br>#003E43 | 900<br>#00282C | 950<br>#001316 |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|

### Red — signal

11 steps · signal at 500 (#862633)

|               |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| 50<br>#F8E9EC | 100<br>#EFC9CF | 200<br>#DD9AA3 | 300<br>#C96872 | 400<br>#B14250 | 500<br>#862633 | 600<br>#6E1F2A | 700<br>#561821 | 800<br>#3E1118 | 900<br>#260A0F | 950<br>#160508 |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|

### Slate / structural spine (not a brand color)

11 steps · structural anchor at 500 (matches site #65758B), black at 950

|               |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |                |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|
| 50<br>#F8FAFC | 100<br>#F1F5F9 | 200<br>#E2E8F0 | 300<br>#CBD5E1 | 400<br>#94A3B8 | 500<br>#64748B | 600<br>#475569 | 700<br>#334155 | 800<br>#1E293B | 900<br>#0F172A | 950<br>#000000 |
|---------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|----------------|



|                    |                        |                        |                     |                      |
|--------------------|------------------------|------------------------|---------------------|----------------------|
| dark-bg<br>#0D0D0D | dark-card-1<br>#1C1C1C | dark-card-2<br>#222222 | dark-row<br>#2A2A2A | dark-line<br>#333333 |
|--------------------|------------------------|------------------------|---------------------|----------------------|

SEMANTIC LAYER

Components reference these tokens, never the primitives directly.

| TOKEN                                                                                                         | MAPS TO               | USED FOR                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|  --color-brand-accent        | teal-500 · #008C95    | Section numbers, the bottom-of-slide accent bar, capability bullets, links, primary buttons, key data highlights, chart primary series.                                                                                                                                               |
|  --color-brand-accent-hover  | teal-600 · #007078    | Hover state for primary buttons and links.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|  --color-brand-accent-active | teal-700 · #00565D    | Active / pressed state. Selected nav item.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|  --color-brand-accent-subtle | teal-50 · #ECF7F8     | Info banners, accent pill backgrounds, ghost button hover.                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|  --color-brand-deep          | teal-900 · #00282C    | Dark teal accents. Footer band when teal is preferred over black.                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|  --color-signal              | red-500 · #862633     | Second accent. Headlines and eyebrows, secondary CTAs and pill buttons, output/risk/optionality columns, award badges, the bar+dot motif, key stats and pull quotes, hairline accents on dark surfaces, critical callouts. Counterweight to teal — use when teal would feel too soft. |
|  --color-signal-subtle     | red-50 · #F8E9EC      | Signal pill background, error banner background.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|  --color-brand-slate       | slate-500 · #64748B   | Structural spine, not a brand color (matches site #65758B). Section accents, icons on light bg, secondary CTAs, tertiary buttons.                                                                                                                                                     |
|  --color-brand-slate-deep  | slate-700 · #334155   | Secondary text on white, dark slate accents. Not a dark-surface anchor — for dark sections use off-black (the Core dark-surface).                                                                                                                                                     |
|  --color-text-default      | neutral-950 · #000000 | Headlines and high-contrast anchors on white.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|  --color-text-body         | slate-800 · #1E293B   | Body copy on white. Slightly softer than pure black for dense reading.                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|  --color-text-secondary    | slate-700 · #334155   | Descriptions, supporting copy, secondary card text.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|  --color-text-muted        | slate-500 · #64748B   | Captions, footnotes, source labels, mono labels.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|                                                                                                               |                       |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |

|                                                                                   |                            |                     |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------|---------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|     | --color-text-faint         | slate-400 · #94A3B8 | Timestamps, subtle metadata, deemphasized labels.                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|   | --color-surface            | #FAFAFA             | Default page surface. Matches the live site (Squarespace --white token = #FAFAFA, not pure white). Sets the off-white tone of the brand.                                                                                                                                  |
|  | --color-surface-pure       | #FFFFFF             | True white. For cards lifted above the page surface, popovers, modals, inputs. Provides subtle contrast against the off-white page.                                                                                                                                       |
|  | --color-surface-soft       | slate-50 · #F8FAFC  | Page section backgrounds, card hover, Quick Win callout.                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|  | --color-surface-muted      | slate-100 · #F1F5F9 | Cards, calculators, secondary panels, table header fills.                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|  | --color-surface-structural | slate-200 · #E2E8F0 | Quiet structural fills, dividers, separator regions when teal would be too loud.                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|  | --color-surface-deep       | dark-bg · #0D0D0D   | <b>Default dark surface.</b> Core anchor (the dark section ground). Use for every dark rhythm break, case-study stat strip, key finding, executive callout, quote interstitial, code block, closing slide.                                                                |
|  | --color-surface-slate-dark | slate-500 · #64748B | Slate emphasis surface (Core slate anchor). A medium cool-gray structural surface, not a "dark" surface. Use when you want the slate structural color to carry the section, structural and warm rather than heavy. Off-black is still the default for dark rhythm breaks. |
|  | --color-border             | slate-200 · #E2E8F0 | Card borders, dividers, hairlines on white.                                                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|  | --color-border-strong      | slate-300 · #CBD5E1 | Stronger dividers, table borders, separators inside cards.                                                                                                                                                                                                                |

#### 04 · TYPE

## FUTURA BUILDS THE STRUCTURE, AVENIR DOES THE READING

Futura Bold for every headline, label, section number, and stat callout. Avenir for body copy, descriptions, captions, and quote text. Avenir is the brand standard. The live Squarespace site falls through to europa because Avenir isn't licensed via Adobe Fonts — europa is the closest free substitute. Per-platform fallback chains below. Left-align everything except three contexts: site/landing-page hero blocks (centered headline + tagline over a full-bleed photo), the deck cover slide, and quote interstitial slides.



|                                                                                                                                                                                         |                                                     |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| CLIENT NAME                                                                                                                                                                             | COVER HEADLINE<br>FUTURA BOLD · 48PT ·<br>UPPERCASE |
| 01                                                                                                                                                                                      | SECTION NUMBER<br>FUTURA BOLD · 13PT · TEAL         |
| Marginal CPA is 4x higher than reported above \$50K spend                                                                                                                               | PAGE TITLE<br>FUTURA BOLD · 24PT                    |
| Holdout testing reveals the truth your dashboard hides                                                                                                                                  | SUBTITLE / LEAD-IN<br>FUTURA BOLD · 18PT            |
| STRATEGIC PILLAR                                                                                                                                                                        | CARD TITLE<br>FUTURA BOLD · 14PT ·<br>UPPERCASE     |
| We do not hide behind dashboards. We tell the truth about what is working and show the math behind it. When the data says a campaign is wasting money, the deck says so on slide three. | BODY COPY<br>AVENIR · 15PX                          |
| Card descriptions and secondary supporting text use this size. Slightly tighter than full body.                                                                                         | SMALL BODY<br>AVENIR · 13PX                         |
| Source: Q4 2025 internal MMM · n=12 accounts                                                                                                                                            | CAPTION / FOOTNOTE<br>AVENIR · 12PX · MUTED         |
| 90                                                                                                                                                                                      | LARGE STAT CALLOUT<br>FUTURA BOLD · 80PT · TEAL     |

### CROSS-PLATFORM FALLBACK CHAINS

Futura + Avenir are the brand standard. They render natively on Mac (both ship with macOS). Other platforms each have a constraint: Squarespace can't license Avenir, Google Slides has neither, Windows ships neither pre-installed. The fallbacks below are the agreed substitutes for each environment.

| PLATFORM                | HEADLINE                    | BODY                         |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------|
| Squarespace (live site) | futura-pt (via Adobe Fonts) | europa (Avenir not licensed) |
|                         |                             |                              |

|                      |                                               |                            |
|----------------------|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------|
| Google Slides        | Jost                                          | Nunito Sans                |
| PowerPoint (Mac)     | Futura                                        | Avenir                     |
| PowerPoint (Windows) | Embed Futura, else Bahnschrift → Trebuchet MS | Embed Avenir, else Calibri |
| PDF (any source)     | Embed at export                               | Embed at export            |

DO

#### EMBED FONTS IN SHARED POWERPOINT FILES

Save > Embed fonts in file. Adds ~200KB. Recipients on Windows see Futura/Avenir as intended instead of Calibri substitutes.

DO

#### USE JOST + NUNITO SANS FOR GOOGLE SLIDES

Both are in the Google Fonts library, both are the closest free matches. Don't fight Slides — pick the substitutes once and apply consistently.

## 05 · SIGNATURE MOTIFS

# FIVE SMALL MARKS THAT MAKE A PAGE READ AS BLACKBIRD

The teal bar with the red dot is the strongest signature. The bottom accent bar grounds every white content slide. Numbered prefixes carry color meaning. Section headers earn a thin colored underline. Bullet dots replace standard bullets.

#### TEAL BAR · RED DOT



Sits directly **below the title** it punctuates, never above. Also used under quotes and as section-end punctuation. Roughly 1 in 3-4 slides. Never inside containers.

**Maximum once per slide** — the motif is a signature, not a repeating decoration. Two on one slide reads as pattern, not punctuation.

#### BOTTOM ACCENT BAR



Full-width teal bar runs along the bottom edge of every white-background content slide. The deck's foundation line.

#### NUMBERED COLORED PREFIX

- 01** Initial Website Review
- 02** Competitor Positioning
- 01** Feature ⇒ Benefit Mapping
- 02** Benefit Ranking

Two-digit number in bold, colored to match the column theme. Teal for inputs/positives, red for outputs/risks. Replaces filled card backgrounds.

#### SECTION HEADER UNDERLINE

### INPUTS

### OUTPUTS

Bold uppercase headline, thin matching colored line beneath. Width matches the headline, not the column. Quieter than a tag, louder than nothing.

#### TEAL BULLET DOT

- Holdout testing across paid channels
- Marginal CPA modeling per spend tier
- Weekly incrementality readouts

8px filled circle, brand teal. Replaces standard bullet characters in lists. No nested bullets — if you need hierarchy, restructure.

## 06 IMAGERY

This band is Layout G running live: full-bleed nightscape, dark overlay to taste, teal section number, no logo, no bottom bar. Drop one of these into the page every few sections, exactly as a deck would.

Photo: Miki Barton, CC BY. See [assets/photography/PHOTOS.md](#)

#### 06 • IMAGERY

## SAN FRANCISCO AT NIGHT, BIRD IMAGERY, TEAL LINE ICONS

Photography lives in two subjects: San Francisco (skyline, urban detail, the bay, shot at dusk or after dark) and bird imagery (blackbirds, ravens, crows, silhouettes against sky). Aesthetic is nightscape — dark, moody, atmospheric. Overlay treatment varies by use; the goal is mood, not a fixed opacity number. Photos appear on the cover, section dividers, and closing slide. Icons are line-stroke teal, on every content card and list row, never on photo slides.

### PHOTOGRAPHY

SF NIGHTSCAPE • DARK OVERLAY TO TASTE

#### PHOTOGRAPHY RULES



|           |                                                                                        |
|-----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Subjects  | SF cityscape and skyline; bird imagery (blackbirds, ravens, crows, silhouettes)        |
| Mood      | Nightscape — dusk, after-dark, atmospheric, low-key                                    |
| Treatment | Dark overlay to taste; goal is mood, not a fixed opacity                               |
| Where     | Cover, section dividers, closing slide, hero blocks                                    |
| Where not | Content slides, cards, dividers within sections                                        |
| No        | Generic stock, daylight skylines, abstract gradients, AI-generated cityscapes or birds |

THE LIBRARY

Fourteen cleared images live in assets/photography/: nine San Francisco nightscapes and five corvids. Every file has a row in PHOTOS.md recording photographer, license, and source. If an image is not in the manifest, it does not ship.



Twin Peaks skyline, blue hour



Bay Bridge light trails



Bay Bridge western span, dusk



Downtown and Bay Bridge



Light field from Bernal Heights



Sutro Tower above the fog



Golden Gate south tower



Golden Gate in night fog



Chinatown, Grant and Pine



Crows on a wire



Wings, silhouette



Crow on branch, storm sky

Raven profile

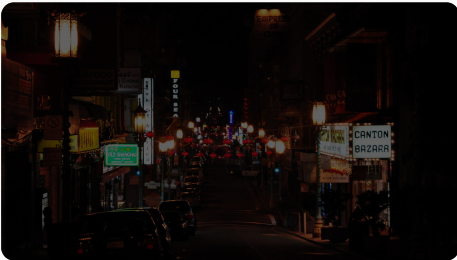
Raven portrait

Licenses: CC0, Public Domain Mark, or CC BY 2.0 (credit kept in PHOTOS.md ). One exception: the Twin Peaks hero predates v3.0 and its license is unverified. Confirm or replace before client-facing use.

OVERLAY TREATMENT



Raw. Too busy to carry type.



Dark overlay to taste. Mood, not a fixed opacity.



Overlay heavy enough that type and logo read cleanly.

ICONS

LINE-STROKE TEAL OR BLACK · ~32PX ON SLIDES, 1.5PX STROKE



ANALYTICS



SEARCH



LAYERS



TARGET



CODE



CHECKLIST

ICON RULES

**Style**Lucide / Feather, line stroke only. No filled shapes, no dual-tone, no novelty illustrations.

**Color (light bg)** Teal (#008C95) for accent / category-marker roles. Black (#0D0D0D) for content / structural roles where icons read like text. Pick one per grid and hold it.

**Color (dark bg)** White. Always. Teal-on-dark goes muddy; black-on-dark disappears.

**Stroke** 1.5px, no fill. Corners are square or barely rounded — no soft consumer shapes.

**Size** ~32px on slides, ~24px in compact rows. Optical-sized in pairs, never stretched.

**Position**Top-left of card, or left of row. Aligned to the cap-height of the headline next to them.

**Where not** Section dividers, quote slides, data tables, cover, closing.

**Consistency**If one item in a grid has an icon, all do. If one is teal, all are teal. No mixed colors in a single grid.

**Container**Bare on white cards. Optional filled-circle treatment (teal-500 with white icon) for hero rows — pick one or the other across the deck, not both.



# DROP INTO A DARK SECTION EVERY FEW SLIDES

Off-black #0D0D0D is the default dark ground. One of these every 3 to 5 slides breaks the white rhythm and resets attention. This band is the rule running live on the page that states it. Red carries the counterweight accent below.

07 · RULES

## HOW TO KEEP IT TIGHT

Eighteen system rules, four slide-composition rules, and a pre-ship checklist. Break these and the system drifts.

DO

WHITE CARRIES THE SURFACE

55-65% of slide and screen area is white. Open and clean, not dark or heavy. Dark surfaces are the exception, used as rhythm breaks every 2-4 slides.

DO

REFERENCE SEMANTIC TOKENS, NOT PRIMITIVES

Buttons use var(--color-brand-accent), not #008C95 or var(--teal-500). The semantic layer is the only contract components touch.

DON'T

HARDCODE HEX VALUES ANYWHERE

If you find yourself typing #008C95 in a component, stop. Either there's already a semantic token for it, or there should be one. Add to the system, then use it.

DO

USE TEAL AS A PRIMARY ACCENT, NOT A PUNCTUATION MARK

Teal can fill surfaces, anchor sections, color CTAs, and underline links — not just dot bullets. Target 10-15% of any view. The constraint is meaning, not count: teal carries positive/primary signal. When everything is teal, that signal stops working.

DO

USE RED AS A SECOND ACCENT, NOT JUST A SIGNAL

Red is the counterweight to teal — declarative, confident, and brand-anchored. Target 8-10% of any view. Use it for headlines and section eyebrows, secondary CTAs and pill buttons, output/risk/optionality columns, award badges, the bar+dot motif, key stats and pull quotes, hairline accents on dark surfaces, and one-per-deck critical callouts. Pair it intentionally against teal so the meanings stay distinct: teal carries primary/positive, red carries emphasis/counterpoint. Avoid red as a full content background, as body copy, or in long runs of solid fill.

DON'T

ADD GRADIENTS OR SATURATED EXTRAS

Flat color only. The four-color palette plus the slate scale and dark surfaces is the entire system. No new colors without a new semantic token.



**DON'T****USE FILLED CONTAINERS FOR CONTENT**

No pastel cards, no warm fills, no rounded boxes with solid backgrounds fighting the text for attention. Containers are outlined with a subtle matching tint (teal-50 or red-50), or they don't exist at all.

**DO****COLOR THE NUMBERED PREFIX TO MATCH MEANING**

Two-digit prefix is teal for inputs, positives, points of difference. Red for outputs, risks, optionality. Slate-500 for neutral context. The number carries the color signal so the title text stays plain.

**DON'T****ADD DECORATIVE LINES UNDER HEADLINES**

A hallmark of generic AI-generated slides. Use whitespace. Two exceptions: the teal-bar-red-dot signature (1-in-3 slides), and the section-header underline that matches headline width, not column width.

**DO****DROP INTO A DARK SECTION EVERY FEW SLIDES FOR EMPHASIS**

Off-black (#0D0D0D) is the default for dark emphasis — it's the Core dark-surface anchor and carries the brand directly. Use it every 3-5 slides to break the white rhythm and signal "this matters" — case-study stat strips, key findings, executive callouts, quote interstitials. Slate-500 (#64748B) is the alternative emphasis surface: a medium cool-gray structural surface (the Core slate anchor itself), used when you want the slate structural color to carry a section, warm and structural rather than heavy. Two emphasis surfaces, both anchored. Dark-section grounds are never slate-700/-800 — those are tone derivatives (slate-800 is the cool dark-card, not a ground).

**DO****TREAT SLATE AS THE STRUCTURAL SPINE, NOT A BRAND COLOR**

Teal and red are the only brand colors. Slate-500 is structure, not identity: it grounds and divides, then recedes. Use it for tertiary CTAs, icon strokes on light bg, dividers between major sections, captions, and the warm emphasis surface. Its hex is Tailwind's slate-500, a workhorse neutral, so never push it forward to carry brand identity.

**DO****USE TEAL, RED, AND SLATE-500 TOGETHER IN STAT GRIDS**

Stat cards can carry all three core colors (teal, red, slate) at once, grouped by intent. Teal carries the primary figures, red the headline/signal numbers (the stats that genuinely "wow"), slate-500 the secondary or contextual stats. Band by row or column so the grouping reads as hierarchy. The thing to avoid is random cell-by-cell alternation, not multi-color stat grids themselves. A 2-teal / 2-red / 2-slate grid is on-brand; a teal/red/teal/red checkerboard is not.

**DO****VARY THE RHYTHM OF EVERY LIST AND TEXT WALL**

Mix fonts (Futura headers, Avenir body), weights (bold key terms inside running prose), color (one teal phrase per paragraph), and bullet styles (teal dot bullets for top-level, no bullets for sub-context). A good content slide has 2-3 different formats running through it. A bad one has eight identical rows.

**DON'T****BULLET EVERY LINE**

If everything is a bullet, the structure stops working — the eye reads the dots, not the meaning. Mix bullet lists with prose paragraphs, callout blocks, stat strips, and icon rows. The variety is the structure. Two consecutive bullet lists on one slide is a smell; rewrite one as prose.

**DON'T****PUT A TOP-EDGE BAR ON A CARD**

Cards stand on their outline, not on a colored bar. The bottom-of-slide accent and the bar+dot signature are the only sanctioned horizontal bars in the system. A teal bar across the top of a card duplicates one of those signatures inside a container — the eye reads the bar, not the card title. White cards get a slate-200 hairline outline. Tinted cards (teal-50, red-50) get a matching tinted border. Nothing on top.

**DON'T****REPEAT THE BAR+DOT MOTIF ON ONE SLIDE**

Maximum once per slide. The bar+dot is a signature, not a divider you sprinkle. Two on one slide reads as decorative pattern, not punctuation — and the second one weakens the first. If you need a second separator, use whitespace or the bottom accent bar.

**DO****PLACE THE BAR+DOT BELOW THE TITLE**

The bar+dot sits directly under the headline it punctuates, never above. Order is title first, mark second, supporting copy third. Above the title it reads as a chip or kicker; below the title it reads as the brand signature finishing the statement.

**DO****USE BLACK ICONS WHEN ICONS PLAY A CONTENT ROLE**

Teal icons read as accents and category markers. Black icons read as content — like text. Use black when icons line up next to body copy and shouldn't compete with the headline color hierarchy. Pick one color per grid and hold it across every item; mixed-color icons in a single grid look like a mistake, not a choice.

DO

LET IMAGES CARRY THE MESSAGE WHEN THEY CAN

A slide can be a single full-bleed image with no text overlay if the image makes the point. SF skyline at dusk after a section divider doesn't need a caption. Don't add text to "balance" the slide — the absence of text is the choice.

DO

MAKE THE TITLE THE MESSAGE, NOT THE TOPIC

"Marginal CPA is 4x higher above \$50K spend" not "CPA Analysis." A reader who only scans titles should understand the deck's argument. Categorical slides (TOC, dividers, roster) can use topic-label titles; everywhere else the title carries the conclusion.

DO

DIRECT THE EYE IN TABLES OF NUMBERS

A table is a tool for proof, not a data dump. The key cell gets a teal left-edge accent, a bold weight, or a teal-100 fill — something that says "this is the point." If nothing on the table is highlighted, the audience doesn't know why the table is there.

DO

ASK IF EVERY NUMBER PUSHES THE NARRATIVE

Each number on a slide must advance the argument. If a stat is interesting but irrelevant, cut it. Numbers compound — five of them on one slide make four of them noise. Rigor is what we sell; selective is the discipline that proves it.

BEFORE YOU SHIP

Final-pass review. Walk every slide top-to-bottom against this list before the deck leaves your hands. Most brand drift is caught here, not in early drafts.

|                 |                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| COLOR BUDGET    | Each slide reads as ~50–55% surface, 12–15% teal, 8–10% red, 12–15% slate, 5–7% black, 5–8% dark slate. No seventh hex.                                                                                  |
| CARDS           | No top-edge bars. White cards have a slate-200 outline; tinted cards use matching teal-200 or red-200 borders.                                                                                           |
| BAR + DOT MOTIF | Sits directly below the title it punctuates, never above. Maximum one per slide. Roughly 1 in 3-4 slides across the deck. Never inside a container.                                                      |
| TITLES          | Each carries the conclusion, not the topic. Scan-only readers should follow the argument.                                                                                                                |
| IMAGES          | Check every image for stretching, squishing, or skew. Aspect ratios preserved. Spacing around images consistent slide-to-slide. No image touches a slide edge unless it's a full-bleed cover or divider. |
| SPACING         | Margins consistent across slides. Card padding matches the spec. No element jammed against another or floating in dead space.                                                                            |
| ICONS           | One color per grid — either all teal or all black. Line stroke only, 1.5px, no fill. If one card has an icon, all cards in that grid have icons.                                                         |
| DARK RHYTHM     | One dark slide every 3-5 slides. Slate-800 by default; off-black only for code or closing.                                                                                                               |
| FONTS           | Futura and Avenir embedded in shared .pptx files. Cross-platform fallbacks set.                                                                                                                          |
| LOGO PLACEMENT  | Bird mark in bottom-right of every content slide. No logo on cover or closing. Horizontal lockup reserved for TOC.                                                                                       |
| NUMBERS         | Every stat advances the argument. Cut interesting-but-irrelevant. Sources cited where claimed.                                                                                                           |
| VOICE           | No hype words ("revolutionary", "best-in-class", "passionate"). Declarative sentences. No exclamation marks.                                                                                             |

Two CSS variable blocks. Primitives at the bottom, semantic on top. Ship as tokens.css.

```
/* primitives.css — raw values, never referenced by components */
:root {
  /* Teal — brand accent, anchored on Blackbird Teal #008C95 */
  --teal-50: #ECF7F8;
  --teal-100: #CFEEF0;
  --teal-200: #A0DCE0;
  --teal-300: #6EC6CB;
  --teal-400: #36AAB1;
  --teal-500: #008C95; /* BRAND */
  --teal-600: #007078;
  --teal-700: #00565D;
  --teal-800: #003E43;
  --teal-900: #00282C;
  --teal-950: #001316;

  /* Red — signal, anchored on #862633 */
  --red-50: #F8E9EC;
  --red-500: #862633; /* SIGNAL */
  --red-700: #561821;
  /* ...full 11-step scale */

  /* Neutrals — cool slate, harmonizes with brand teal */
  --neutral-50: #F8FAFC;
  --neutral-100: #F1F5F9;
  --neutral-200: #E2E8F0;
  --neutral-300: #CBD5E1;
  --neutral-500: #64748B;
  --neutral-700: #334155;
  --neutral-800: #1E293B;
  --neutral-900: #0F172A;
  --neutral-950: #000000; /* brand black */

  /* Dark surfaces */
  --dark-bg: #0D0D0D;
  --dark-card1: #1C1C1C;
  --dark-card2: #222222;
}

/* semantic.css — the active system. Components only use these. */
:root {
  --color-brand-accent: var(--teal-500);
  --color-brand-accent-hover: var(--teal-600);
  --color-brand-accent-active: var(--teal-700);
  --color-brand-accent-subtle: var(--teal-50);
  --color-brand-deep: var(--teal-900);
  --color-signal: var(--red-500);
  --color-signal-subtle: var(--red-50);
  --color-brand-slate: var(--neutral-500); /* structural spine (not a brand color), matches site */
  --color-brand-slate-deep: var(--neutral-700);

  --color-text-default: var(--neutral-950);
  --color-text-body: var(--neutral-800);
  --color-text-secondary: var(--neutral-700);
  --color-text-muted: var(--neutral-500);
  --color-text-inverse: #FFFFFF;
```

```
--color-surface: #FAFAFA; /* off-white, matches site */
--color-surface-pure: #FFFFFF; /* raised cards, modals */
--color-surface-soft: var(--neutral-50);
--color-surface-muted: var(--neutral-100);
--color-surface-structural: var(--neutral-200);
--color-surface-deep: var(--dark-bg); /* DEFAULT DARK — Core anchor (dark ground) #0D0D0D */
--color-surface-slate-dark: var(--neutral-500); /* slate emphasis surface — slate-500 anchor (Core) */

--color-border: var(--neutral-200);
--color-border-strong: var(--neutral-300);

/* v3.0 — AA-safe small-text accent. Use for links, eyebrows, section
  numbers, and any teal text below 18px on light surfaces. */
--color-link: var(--teal-600);
--color-link-hover: var(--teal-700);

/* Type stacks — Avenir is brand standard. europa is the Squarespace
  fallback (Avenir not licensed via Adobe Fonts). See section 03 for per-platform map. */
--font-headline: "Futura", "futura-pt", "Jost", "Trebuchet MS", system-ui, sans-serif;
--font-body: "Avenir", "europa", "Nunito Sans", "Calibri", system-ui, sans-serif;
}
```

09 • EXAMPLES

# THE SYSTEM IN COMPONENTS

Every element here references semantic tokens. Swap teal-500 to a different hex and watch all of these update at once.

## THE DECK AT A GLANCE



The canonical sequence from the spec: cover, TOC, content, a photo divider per section, a dark break every 3 to 5 slides, closing on off-black. White carries; photo and dark slides are the punctuation.

## SLIDE GALLERY

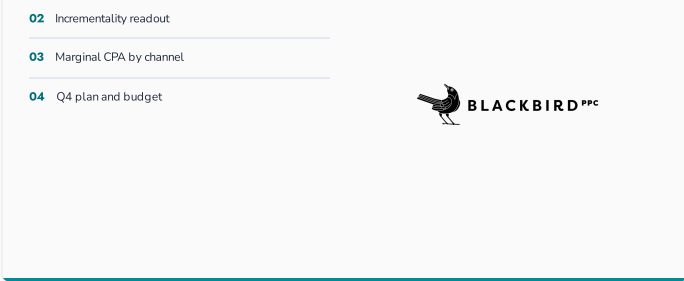
Each layout in the spec, rendered at slide scale. The chart slide below this gallery is Layout A; Inputs/Outputs, POD/POP, Solid Callout, Roadmap, and the Dark Emphasis Strip are specced as full components further down.

### Contents

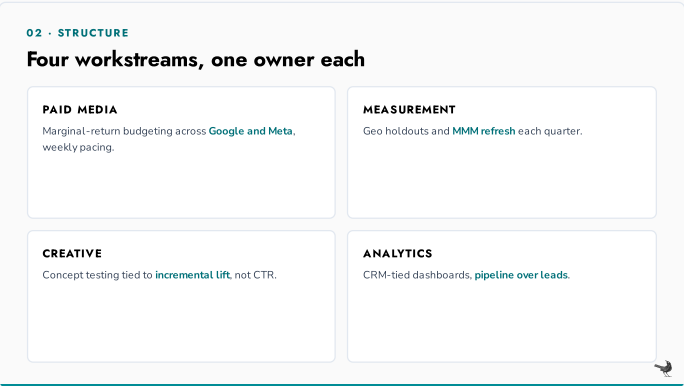
- 01 Performance summary



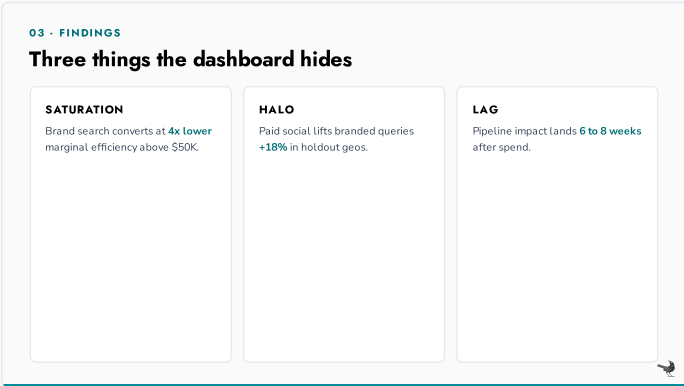
**H · COVER** — full-bleed nightscape, pure black overlay, no logo, no bottom bar. The client name does the work.



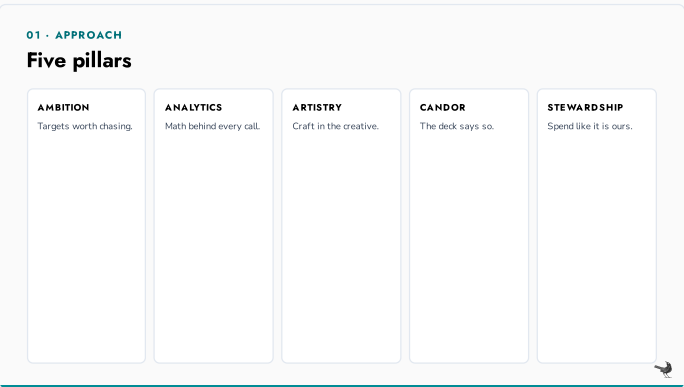
**TOC** — the one slide that carries the horizontal lockup, right-center. Numbered rows in teal-600.



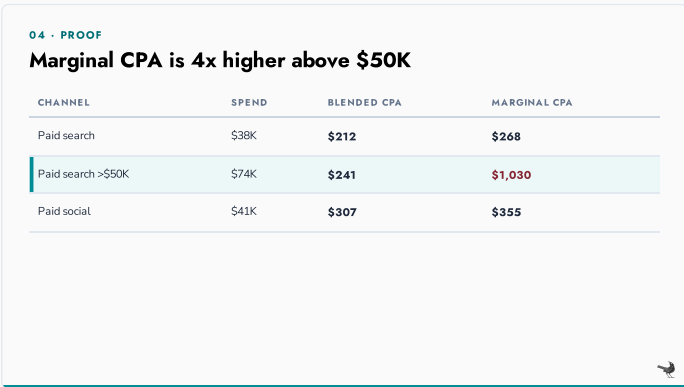
**B · TWO-COLUMN CARDS** — 2x2 grid, white cards on the off-white surface, no top-edge bars, one teal phrase per card.



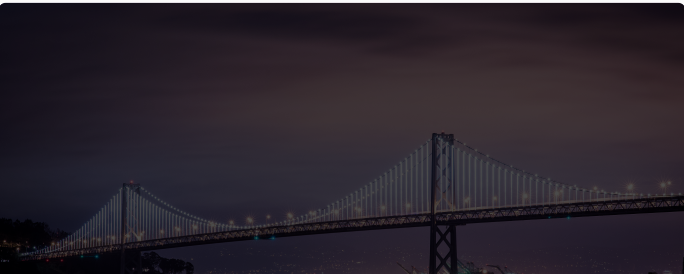
**C · THREE-COLUMN CARDS** — same card spec, three across. Title carries the conclusion, not the topic.



**D · PILLARS** — five narrow cards. The only layout that runs five across; copy stays under ten words per card.



**F · DATA TABLE** — a table is for proof, not a dump. Teal left-edge accent marks the row that is the point; red on the number that hurts.



## 03 PERFORMANCE

**G · PHOTO DIVIDER** — section number at 88pt-equivalent in teal, title in white, overlay to taste. No logo, no bar.

05 · NEXT

### Before the next QBR

- 01 Launch the geo holdout**  
Two matched markets, four weeks, brand search off.
- 02 Rebalance to marginal return**  
Shift \$24K from saturated brand into prospecting.
- 03 Wire pipeline to the dashboard**  
CRM join lands revenue, not leads, on every view.

**K · NUMBERED LIST** — teal two-digit prefixes replace bullets. Bold lead, one supporting line, never more than five rows.

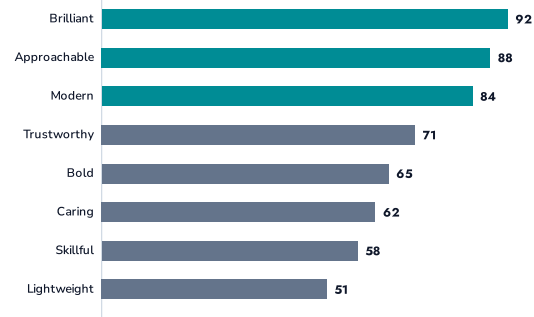
**I · QUOTE INTERSTITIAL** — off-black, one quote, teal attribution. No logo; the quote is the slide.

THANK YOU

**J · CLOSING** — off-black, two words, centered. No logo, no contact block; contact details belong in the email.

## Top brand qualities = Brilliant + Approachable + Modern

**BRAND QUALITY SCORES**  
Customer + employee panel · n=240



### Tensions

**Brilliant + Approachable:** smart, not intimidating

**Bold + Caring:** confident, not aggressive

**Modern + Trustworthy:** new, not unproven

**Lightweight + Skillful:** easy, not trivial

**Most-used slide layout, 16:9 PowerPoint widescreen.** Chart left, text right, two fonts plus bold weight for emphasis. Title carries the message. Chart uses the canonical series — teal for the top three qualities (the ones the title elevates), slate for the rest. Bird mark only in the corner; the horizontal lockup is reserved for TOC and cover slides. Teal bar grounds the bottom edge.

## CARD PATTERN

When a layout calls for cards, this is the spec. Page surface stays #FAFAFA. White cards sit on top in pure white with a thin slate-200 outline and a 10px radius — just enough contrast to lift the card off the page without shadow. The slate-200 outline is specifically for white cards on the off-white surface; tinted cards (teal-50, red-50) use matching tinted borders (teal-200, red-200), and dark cards skip the outline entirely. **No top-edge accent bars on cards.** Ever.

### CARD 01

Pure white background lifts off the off-white page surface. The thin slate outline does the rest of the visual separation work.

### CARD 02

10px radius on every corner. No drop shadows, no glows, no inner shadows. Depth comes from the contrast between #FAFAFA and #FFFFFF.

### CARD 03

1px outline in slate-200 (#E2E8F0). The lightest visible step in the slate scale — reads as a hairline, not a frame.

|                 |                                                                                                                                   |
|-----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PAGE SURFACE    | #FAFAFA — the off-white that matches the live site                                                                                |
| CARD BACKGROUND | #FFFFFF — pure white, lifted above the page                                                                                       |
| OUTLINE COLOR   | #E2E8F0 (slate-200) — for white cards on FAFAFA. Tinted cards use teal-200 or red-200 to match the tint.                          |
| OUTLINE WIDTH   | 1px                                                                                                                               |
| BORDER RADIUS   | 10px (--radius-lg)                                                                                                                |
| PADDING         | 24px default. 18-22px tight, 32px generous                                                                                        |
| TOP ACCENT BAR  | None. Ever. Cards never carry top-edge teal bars — that pattern is reserved for the bottom-of-slide accent and the bar+dot motif. |
| SHADOW          | None. Depth comes from the surface contrast, not drop shadows                                                                     |

Every card in this design system follows this spec — rule cards, motif cards, component examples, token tables. Reuse the pattern instead of inventing a new container.

### BUTTONS — DEFAULT UPPERCASE RECTANGULAR

GET A PROPOSAL

TALK TO US

CASE STUDIES

### PILL OUTLINE — FORM CTAS

Submit

Send message

### TAGS & PILLS

STRATEGIC PILLAR

RISK

CONTEXT

AWARD 2025

### STAT CALLOUT

90

NPS score across active accounts. Source: Q1 2026 client survey, n=47.

### BRAND-ONLY STATE DOTS — TEAL POSITIVE, SLATE NEUTRAL, RED NEGATIVE

● Pacing on track ● Budget at 85% ● Spend exceeded

### INPUTS / OUTPUTS — NUMBERED LIST, OUTLINED + TINTED

## INPUTS

**01** Initial Website Review

**02** Competitor Positioning

**03** Kickoff Meeting

**04** Survey Rankings & Write-ins

**05** Competitors Visual Audit

## OUTPUTS

**01** Feature  $\Rightarrow$  Benefits Mapping

**02** Benefit Ranking

**03** Core Offering Identification

**04** Bain's Elements of Value

**05** Resonating Focus

### ICON LIST — LINE-STROKE TEAL ICONS, BOLD HEADLINE + GRAY DESCRIPTION



#### Benchmark numbers front and centre

94% cost, 4x, 0 JVM lead the hero stat strip. The draft does what EMR does with 4.5x, but louder and earlier.



#### Migration friction dissolved by a code diff

The one-line before/after swapping the endpoint string is the single most persuasive element on the page.



#### OSS vs. managed tier clearly separated

A two-card layout distinguishes self-hosted Sail from the managed platform. Engineers see their on-ramp clearly.



#### Agentic AI retained for VC signalling

The badge keeps "agentic AI" visible to investors without pushing it into the H1, which stays engineer-focused.

### POD / POP / OPTIONALITY STACK — COLORED LABELS, TEAL DIVIDERS

#### POINT OF DIFFERENCE

#### ~94% lower compute cost vs Spark

The only LakeSail prop with quantified, buyer-verifiable magnitude. ClickBench-anchored. Survives 12-18 months as the lead.

#### POINT OF PARITY

#### Open lakehouse compatibility

Spark Connect protocol. Iceberg and Delta. Drop-in for existing Spark code. Removes the switching objection.

#### OPTIONALITY

#### Agent-native architecture

### SOLID COLOR CALLOUT — TEAL BLOCK, BOLD BLACK TEXT

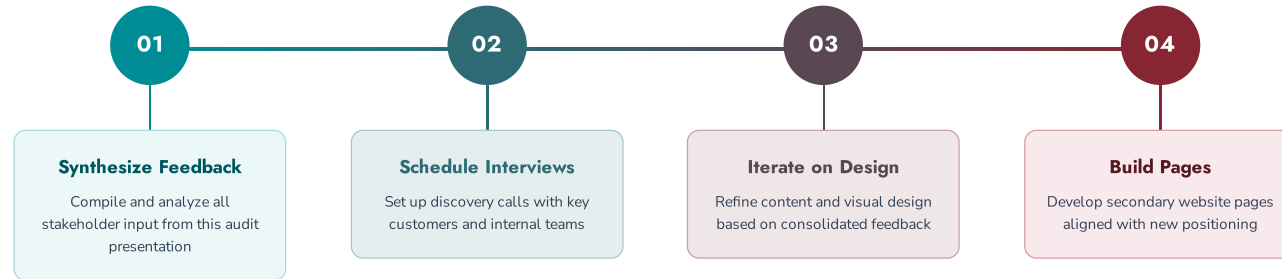
**Everything Spark does. Faster, cheaper, and ready for agents.**

Replaces the typical white-card-with-quote pattern. The block IS the emphasis. Use once per slide, never two solid blocks side by side.



Long-game moat, not the 2026 sale. Hedged bet. If the agent thesis lands, the resonating focus shifts here in 3-5 years.

#### ROADMAP SLIDE — EXAMPLE OF A GOOD SLIDE



Numbered circles in horizontal sequence, color-graded from teal (now, first) to red (later, future). 3–5 steps; more than 5 reads as a checklist. Use for next-steps, project phases, sequenced processes. Titles are the verb of the work, not "Next Steps." Card text is centered — the one place we break left-align, mirroring the symmetry of the circle above.

07

OFF-BLACK #0D0D0D · DEFAULT DARK

## OFF-BLACK IS THE DEFAULT DARK SURFACE

The Core dark-surface anchor (the dark section ground). Use for every dark rhythm break: section divider emphasis, case-study stat strips, key findings, executive callouts, quote interstitials, code blocks, closing slide. Teal accents carry across cleanly; dark surfaces skip the bottom accent bar and carry no card bars.

08

SLATE-500 #64748B · SLATE EMPHASIS SURFACE

## SLATE-500 IS THE SLATE EMPHASIS SURFACE (CORE ANCHOR)

The slate structural color (#64748B) used as a full surface. Not "dark" — medium cool-gray. Use when you want the section to feel structural and warm rather than heavy: capability dividers, slate-themed quote interstitials, the secondary kind of emphasis. Two emphasis surfaces in the system, both anchored: off-black for heavy, slate-500 for warm. No interpolated slate-700/-800 surfaces.

#### CASE STUDIES

## Performance to be proud of

Four enterprise programs. Every number sourced from internal QBR decks and weekly performance reviews.



8X



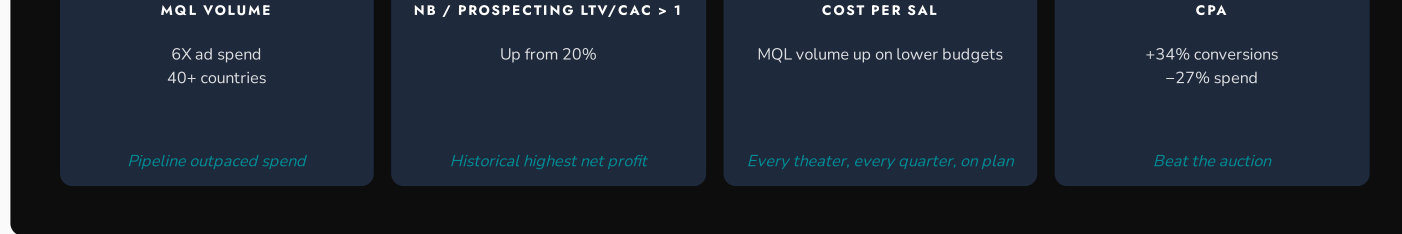
100%

NUTANIX

-49%



-45%



**Dark emphasis section.** Off-black background (#0D0D0D), four cool dark-cards on dark slate (#1E293B), white logo frames, big teal stats, white labels, teal italic outcomes. No bars on the cards — the stat number carries the brand. Slate-500 (#64748B) is the alternative emphasis surface for warm/structural emphasis — both are Core anchors. Use one of these every 3-5 slides to break the white rhythm.

Blackbird PPC Design System

v3.0 · Core Six: brand = teal + red; surface = FAFAFA; structure/ink = slate, black, dark slate (#1E293B); off-black #0D0D0D = dark ground. No bars on cards. FFFFFF cards, 1px slate-200 outline, 10px radius, no shadows